ANDHRA PRADESH

THREE IS COMPANY

By Amarnath K. Menon



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A tight fight is on the cards with the Telugu Desam Party (TDP), the Jana Sena Party (JSP) and the BJP readying for a joint assault on the ruling Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) in the parliamentary and assembly polls in Andhra Pradesh.

For the 73-year-old N. Chandrababu Naidu, who has headed the TDP for three decades and has been chief minister longer than anyone, the 2024 polls, by own admission, will be his last. Sensing that the TDP may not be able to triumph on its own, Naidu has joined a tripartite alliance. On March 9, it finally reached an agreement on contesting the 17 Lok Sabha seats in the state, with six seats to the BJP and two to the JSP (the stalemate was broken after two rounds of talks with JSP founder and actor Pawan Kalyan conceding a seat to the saffron party in the interests of a combined fight).

For the assembly election happening alongside, the TDP will contest 144 seats, JSP 21 and the BJP 10 in the 175-member house. Calling it a win-win scenario, Naidu forecasts a clean sweep for the alliance. The TDP has, over the past two years, been keen to position itself alongside the BJP as a check on the ruling YSRCP. This, despite suspicions that the YSRCP has had the covert blessings of the saffron party for the past five years.

Naidu's party is also hoping that a strong alliance with the BJP will work in its favour post-election, especially with the steady hum of central investigation agencies buzzing over the state. Their joint effort had enabled the TDP to form the government in 2014. Naidu broke the alliance in 2018, citing the failure of the Centre to give Andhra special category status. What seemed a political move ahead of the 2019 election boomeranged on the TDP. In 2019, with the BJP staying out and the JSP going its way, the rival YSRCP headed by Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy scored a landslide win—151 of the 175 assembly seats and 22 of the 25 Lok Sabha seats in the state. Anti-incumbency aside, the vote share

TELANGANA

KCR LOOKS FOR MAYA

By Amarnath K. Menon

A year is a long time in politics, and no one knows it better than Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) chief and former chief minister K. Chandrashekar Rao (KCR), who is now finding it difficult to field worthy contestants for the 17 Lok Sabha seats in Telangana. After changing his party's name in October 2022, KCR had launched grand plans to make his party national. Now, three of his nine sitting MPs are contesting on BJP and Congress tickets, compelling a desperate KCR to announce, on March 5, that he was allying with the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) for the general election.

Following the debacle in the November 2023 assembly poll, not many are eager to contest on a BRS ticket. Some of the leaders sounded by the BRS are reluctant given the perception that there is still anger against the party among voters. To add to KCR's discomfiture, several of his 39 MLAs have begun calling on Chief Minister A. Revanth Reddy, fuelling speculation of a group deserting the BRS for the Congress once the parliamentary election is over.

The coming election is increasingly being perceived as a battle between the ruling Congress and the BJP, though the two had just seven MPs between them in 2019. At least four ex-BRS